

Get started with jQuery Mobile

>jQuery Mobile is an expansion, or plug-in, for jQuery that enables you—the developer—to build mobile-centric UIs. We show you how> by Kshitij Sobti

jQuery is a framework that simplifies common JavaScript routines and operations. It requires knowledge of JavaScript and by itself only provides core routines that can be used to build your own apps. The jQuery Mobile framework builds on jQuery, and realises a simple HTML page as a dynamic touch-friendly web page. Yes, all jQuery mobile needs from you is a standard HTML page with all your data, which it will then translate automatically into an Ajax-driven mobile- and touch-friendly web application.

To keep it simple, we'll look at creating a "things to-do" app using jQuery Mobile. You will only be able to add items to the list. But before we begin, here's a look at basic jQuery Mobile concepts.

How jQuery Mobile works

While jQuery expects no formal structure from your HTML code, and can be used to build pretty much any kind of web application, it now has a more narrow goal and approach. It expects your pages to include specific attributes that define how it will function.

In a jQuery application, you will assign certain roles to different elements in your HTML code. One role is that of **page**, complete with header, footer and content. Assign it a **button** role and a link quickly becomes a button. Similarly you can apply a **listview** role to turn an ordinary list into a rich touch-friendly clickable list.

When you include jQuery Mobile in your code, it does a number of things. It looks at all the HTML elements to which you have assigned roles and other attributes, and it automatically enhances them based on your settings. It also converts all your links to AJAX driven links so instead of loading a refreshing the page and loading a new link, it just loads the link in the same page, which makes your web site all the more like a dynamic app.

While jQuery Mobile does make your web site more dynamic, it expects a static page to begin with. If you have a static page with properly defined roles, jQuery will automatically enhance it and make it dynamic. If however, you have content on your page that changes after you have loaded the page, for example pulling items from a news feed or such, it will not work out of the box, but will need some JavaScript code.

jQuery Mobile Boilerplate

Let's get the boilerplate jQuery Mobile code out of the way. This code sets up your application, and includes the standard jQuery and jQuery Mobile CSS and JavaScript code. Here it is:

```
<html><head><title>My Todo App</title>
```

```
<meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1">
<link rel="stylesheet" href="http://code.jquery.com/mobile/1.1.0/jquery.mobile-1.1.0.min.css" />
<script src="http://code.jquery.com/jquery-1.7.1.min.js"></script>
<script src="http://code.jquery.com/mobile/1.1.0/jquery.mobile-1.1.0.min.js"></script></head><body></body></html>
```

Here we have linked the files directly from the jQuery website so it will just work.

Adding a page

A page is a basic component of jQuery Mobile app. A single HTML file / app can define multiple pages, and navigate between them.

Inside the body tag here we will define a page. A page can have a header, content area and footer. The header area can have a title, and even buttons if you like. The footer could have a toolbar for switching between pages or views. Here is a simple page:

```
<div data-role="page" id="home">
<div data-role="header"></div>
<div data-role="content"> </div>
<div data-role="footer"></div></div>
```

Here the page is defined by a simple **div** tag, however it is given a **data-role** attribute that is set to "page". We have also assigned an **id** of "home" which will come in handy for navigation.

Adding the Todo elements

Our todo app is simple, it just needs a text area for entering a todo item, a button for the adding it, and a list. We will add the text input and button to the footer, while the list of items will be in the content area.

jQuery Mobile automatically enhances most form elements to make them work better on touch screens. It will convert any any links in the header or footer to buttons. For buttons in the content area, you just need to add a link with the **data-role** attribute set to "button". You can even add an icon for the button by adding the **data-icon** attribute and setting it to one of the the icons that ship with jQuery Mobile.

To add a text area and button to the footer we add the following code to the **div** with the footer role:

```
<input type="text" name="todoitem">
<a data-icon="plus" data-role="button">Add</a>
```

Now let's add the list to the content area with the following code:

```
<ol id="todolist" data-role="listview"></ol>
```